10th Class English • Unit 10 • Punjab Board (New Syllabus 2026)

The Three Questions — Leo Tolstoy

Fully solved exercises: comprehension, MCQs, variety of readings, direct and indirect narration, philosopher's circle, summary writing

A. The Story at a Glance

Writer: Leo Tolstoy (1828–1910), a Russian writer famous for stories with a moral. **Type:** a parable — a short narrative that teaches a lesson. **Characters:** the king, the learned men of his kingdom, the wise hermit, and the wounded stranger (the king's enemy). **Setting:** a kingdom and a wood where the hermit lives in a small hut and digs beds for his garden.

Central idea: the three questions have one answer between them — the most important time is **now**, the most important person is **the one you are with**, and the most important work is **to do him good**. A man who serves the person in front of him at the present moment is already living rightly.

Part of the story	What happens
The questions	A king wants to know (i) the right time to begin every work, (ii) the right people to listen to, and (iii) the most important thing to do — so that he may never fail in anything.
The learned men	They give conflicting answers: plan a timetable / watch carefully / consult a magician; listen to councillors / priests / doctors / soldiers; the most important thing is science, or fighting, or the worship of God. The king is not satisfied and rewards nobody.
The hermit	The king goes in simple clothes to a hermit famous for wisdom. The hermit is digging the ground, weak and tired, and answers nothing. The king digs the beds for him and spends the night there.
The wounded man	A man runs out of the wood, wounded, and collapses. The king washes and bandages his wound and stays awake the whole night caring for him.
The enemy	The stranger confesses that he is the king's enemy, who came to kill him, was wounded by the king's own guards, and would have died if the king had not helped him. He asks for forgiveness and becomes the king's servant.
The answers	The hermit explains: the king had already received his answers. The most important time was when he was digging — that is, **now**; the most important person was the hermit, and then the wounded man — **the person he was with**; the most important work was to **do that person good**. Had he not stayed, the enemy would have killed him on the road.

questions

1. What three questions did the king want to find answers to?

The king wanted to know three things: **(i)** the right time to begin every work — the best moment to do a thing so that he might never fail; **(ii)** the right people to listen to — whose advice he should follow above everyone else's; and **(iii)** the most important thing to do — the work that mattered more than all other works. He believed that if he knew these three things he would always succeed in whatever he undertook.

2. Why did the king first turn to the learned men in his kingdom?

Because he thought that learning and book-knowledge were the road to wisdom. His kingdom had men famous for their scholarship, and a king is expected to consult the most educated people before taking a decision. He therefore announced the three questions and invited all the learned men to answer them, promising a reward to the one whose answer he accepted.

3. Why was the king dissatisfied with the answers he received from the learned men?

He was dissatisfied because the answers were different from one another and each seemed only partly true. For the right time, some said that a king should prepare a timetable of days and months, others said that he should watch everything carefully, and some said that only magicians could tell the right time. For the right people, some named the councillors, some the priests, some the doctors and some the soldiers. For the most important work, some said science, some said fighting and some said the worship of God. Since the answers contradicted each other, he could not choose any of them and refused to reward anyone.

4. Who did the king decide to visit after the learned men could not help him?

He decided to visit a **hermit** who lived in a wood and was famous for his wisdom. The king knew that this man was a saintly person who was content with little and wanted nothing from the world, so his advice would not be bought with money. The king put on simple clothes, left his guards and servants on the road, and walked to the hermit's hut.

5. How did the hermit respond when the king asked him the three questions?

The hermit gave no answer at all. He was digging the ground in front of his hut, and when the king repeated the three questions he only said that the king must be tired and offered him his spade instead of his opinion. When the king had dug two beds the hermit took the spade back, and when the king insisted on his questions the holy man still kept silent and went on with his work. The answers came at the end, after the king had spent the night caring for the wounded stranger.

studysapiens.com

C. Choose the Correct Option (MCQs) — solved with key

1. Who wanted answers to three important questions?

farmer hermit
king soldier

Answer: king — The story opens with a king who wanted to know the right time, the right people and the most important work.

2. Whom did the king first ask for advice?

magicians learned men
hermit soldiers

Answer: learned men — He first sent for all the learned men of his kingdom.

3. Who did the king finally visit for wisdom?

doctor priest
hermit farmer

Answer: hermit — The hermit was famous for his wisdom and lived in a wood.

4. What was the hermit doing when the king arrived?

reading sleeping
digging praying

Answer: digging — He was digging the ground in front of his hut, and he was tired.

5. Whom did the king save?

enemy philosopher
lawyer hermit

Answer: enemy — The wounded stranger confessed that he was the king's enemy who had come to kill him.

D. Analysing a Variety of Readings

The four questions below ask you to carry Tolstoy's three questions into other kinds of texts — a poem, a personal recount, a narrative and a play. Model answers are given for each.

1. Poetry. How might a poet answer Tolstoy's question, “When is the right time to do things?” in his or her poem?

A poet would answer through an image rather than an argument. He would probably say that the right time is **this very second** — the moment the leaf falls, the moment the lamp is lit, the moment the mother calls from the door. A poem on this theme would use a fast-moving rhythm for the hours that run away and a slow, soft line for the instant in which a man finally decides to act. For example: “Not someday's sun, not tomorrow's rain — / the hour is this one, knocking at your pane.” The poet's answer, in short, would be the same as the hermit's, but it would arrive as a picture in the reader's mind instead of as a lesson.

Studysapiens.com

2. Personal recounts (diary entries, biographies). If you wrote a diary entry today, how would you show who was the "most important person" in your experience?

A diary entry shows the most important person not by announcing him but by giving him the largest space. I would write the entry in the first person, describe that person's words in direct quotation, and tell how the meeting changed my day. **Model entry:** "Tuesday, 4th November. Today the most important person in my day was not my teacher or my friend, but the old man who sells fruit outside the school gate. He had no customer for an hour, so I bought two oranges and sat with him for five minutes. He told me his sons work in another city and that he has not seen them since Eid. When I got up, he held my hand and said, 'You gave me more than money, beta.' I came home quieter than I went out. Perhaps the whole day had been arranged only for those five minutes."

3. Narratives (fables, legends). How does the main character's journey answer one of Tolstoy's three questions?

Take a legend of a traveller who sets out to find a magic stone. All the way he asks who can tell him where it is, and everyone he meets is busy with some small work of their own — a farmer whose bullock has fallen, a child who has lost her way, a widow whose roof has broken. He stops each time and helps, and because of these delays he never reaches the mountain where the stone was said to lie. In the end he learns from an old woman that the stone was never the point: **the most important person was the one in front of him, and the most important work was the help his hands were already giving**. This is exactly Tolstoy's third answer: the good of the person beside you here and now, not a distant prize.

4. Drama (play scripts). How could a character's choices in a play answer Tolstoy's question about "the most important thing to do"?

In a play, a character is known by what he does in the crisis, because the audience watches the choice instead of hearing it explained. Suppose a young minister in a court drama must sign a paper that will save the treasury but ruin a widow's land. Stage directions can show his struggle — [he walks to the window], [he puts down the pen] — and then he sets the paper aside and says, "The treasury can wait for another budget; the widow cannot wait for another season." That single choice answers Tolstoy's question on the stage: **the most important thing to do is the good that the present moment puts within your reach**, even at a cost. Drama is powerful here because the audience sees the cost as well as the decision.

E. Vocabulary and Grammar — Direct and Indirect Narration

Direct narration gives the speaker's exact words inside inverted commas. **Indirect narration** reports those words in our own way, and three things usually change: the **tense** (present → past, past → past perfect, will → would), the **pronouns** (I → he, my → his), and the **words of time and place** (now → then, today → that day, tomorrow → the next day, yesterday → the day before).

studysapiens.com

Tasks from the book	Answer (indirect speech)
1. “I need the answers right now,” said the king.	The king said that he needed the answers right then.
2. “You made the right choice yesterday,” said the hermit.	The hermit said that the king had made the right choice the day before.
3. “I have wasted my time,” the king admitted.	The king admitted that he had wasted his time.
4. “I shall ask the hermit again,” the king decided.	The king decided that he would ask the hermit again.
5. “You may find the answer soon,” said the hermit.	The hermit said that the king might find the answer soon.
6. “I will meet you tomorrow,” the king promised.	The king promised that he would meet him the next day.
7. “Who is the most important person?” the king asked.	The king asked who the most important person was.
8. “Dig the ground for me,” the king commanded.	The king commanded (ordered) the hermit to dig the ground for him.
9. “Please forgive me,” the enemy said to the king.	The enemy requested the king to forgive him.
10. “You should focus on helping others,” the hermit suggested.	The hermit suggested that the king should focus on helping others. (or: The hermit advised the king to focus on helping others.)

Remember four points: past tense of the reporting verb, change of pronouns, change of time words, and — for questions, orders and requests — a change of word order and verb form.

Extra practice (mixed)	Answer
The king said, “I want to find the answers today.”	The king said that he wanted to find the answers that day.
The hermit said, “You must listen carefully.”	The hermit said that the king had to listen carefully.
The king said, “Answer my questions!”	The king ordered the hermit to answer his questions.
The king said, “Please help me find the answer.”	The king requested the hermit to help him find the answer.

F. Oral Communication Skills — Philosopher's Circle

In a philosopher's circle each student states one opinion clearly, gives a reason, and then answers one question from the class. The three guiding questions and model answers follow.

1. When is the best time to do things?

Opinion: the best time is **now**, the moment the duty appears. **Reason:** the past is gone and the future is not in our hands, so the present is the only time in which we have any power to act. **Example:** if I plan to help my mother but wait for a convenient hour, the hour never comes; if I get up at once, the work is finished in ten minutes. **Answer to a class question "but should we not plan first?":** planning is good, but planning is not the work; a small beginning now is worth more than a perfect plan for tomorrow.

2. Who is the most important person?

Opinion: the most important person is the one who is with me at this moment, whoever he may be. **Reason:** I cannot do good to a person who is not present, and the person in front of me has been brought to me by Allah's will at this very hour. **Example:** the hermit was a poor old man in a wood, not a king, and he was still the most important person in the kingdom that morning. **Answer to a class question "what about your family?":** my family is usually the person in front of me, and that is exactly why the rule works — the nearest duty comes first.

3. What is the most important thing to do?

Opinion: the most important thing to do is **to do good to the person who is with you**. **Reason:** great deeds wait for great occasions, but kindness never has to wait; and a single good act, like the king's bandaging of a wounded stranger, can change an enemy into a friend. **Example:** the king dug the hermit's beds and saved the wounded man — two small acts, and both of them saved his kingdom and his life. **Answer to a class question "is study not more important?":** study is important, but it is important for people; the good we do along the way is the purpose, not the delay.

G. Writing Skills — Summary of "The Three Questions"

A summary is much shorter than the original, is written in your own words, keeps only the main points in their proper order, and adds no opinion or criticism. The five steps are: read carefully, divide the text into sections, pick the key point of each section, write the summary, then check it against the text.

1. Write the summary of "The Three Questions" by Leo Tolstoy.

A king once decided that he could never fail in anything if he always knew three things: the right time to begin every work, the right people to listen to, and the most important thing to do. He called the learned men of his kingdom, but their answers contradicted one another and he was not satisfied with any of them.

He then went in simple clothes to a hermit famous for his wisdom. The hermit was digging the ground in front of his hut and gave no answer to the three questions. The king took the spade and dug the beds for him. In the evening a wounded stranger ran out of the wood and collapsed; the king washed his wound and bandaged it, and stayed awake the whole night caring for him. In the morning the stranger confessed that he was the king's enemy, that he had come to kill him, that the king's guards had wounded him, and that the king's care had saved his life. He

studysapiens.com

asked for forgiveness and promised to serve the king.

The hermit then told the king that his questions were already answered. The most important time had been the time he was digging, because it was the only time in which he had any power to act; the most important person had been the hermit, and then the wounded man, because he was the person present; and the most important work had been to do good to that person. If he had not stayed, he would have been killed on his way home. So the answer to all three questions is the same: the most important time is now, the most important person is the one you are with, and the most important thing to do is to do him good.

H. The Message of the Story

Tolstoy's parable teaches that wisdom is not a set of clever rules but a way of living. We spend our lives asking “when”, “who” and “what”, and the answer is always the same: **this moment**, **this person**, **this kindness**. The learned men lost themselves in arguments because they looked for one answer for all occasions; the hermit answered by acting, and his action turned an enemy into a friend. The story also shows the value of humility in the king: he left his throne, dug like a labourer, and nursed a stranger, and he received his wisdom only when he stopped asking and started serving.

Points to Remember

• Writer: Leo Tolstoy; type: parable (a story that teaches a lesson).

• The three questions: (i) the right time to begin everything, (ii) the right people to listen to, (iii) the most important thing to do.

• The learned men gave conflicting answers, so the king went to a hermit in the wood.

• The hermit was digging his garden and answered only at the end, through the king's own experience.

• The king saved a wounded stranger who proved to be his enemy, and the man asked for forgiveness.

• The answers: the most important time is NOW; the most important person is the one you are with; the most important thing to do is to do that person good.

• Direct narration = exact words in inverted commas; indirect = change of tense, pronouns and time words (now → then, today → that day, tomorrow → the next day, yesterday → the day before).

• Questions, orders and requests change form in indirect speech: asked what/who…; ordered/commanded … to + verb; requested/advised … to + verb.

• Summary: shorter, in your own words, main points in order, no opinion.